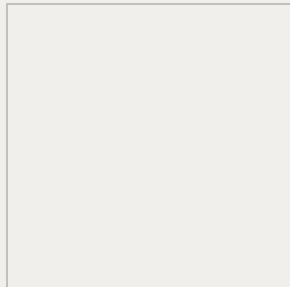


IN CONTEXT

The Great American Songbook

In the 1920s, the advent of radio and improvements in gramophone recording led to a tremendous boom in the popular music business, which had previously been dominated by the sales of sheet music from the publishers of the now famous Tin Pan Alley district of New York. Composers such as George Gershwin, Cole Porter, Irving Berlin, Jerome Kern, Johnny Mercer, and Richard Rodgers learned their trade in Tin Pan Alley, but now turned their attention to writing songs for the Broadway musical theater and the movies. Reaching an unprecedentedly wide audience, these show tunes quickly became “standards”—favorites that were performed and recorded by a huge range of artists. The songs became known as “American Standards” and are often referred to collectively as The Great American Songbook.



GRAMOPHONE PLAYER WITH SIDE HANDLE, EARLY 1920s

Gershwin was the second of four sons born to the Gershowitz family, Ukrainian and Lithuanian Jews who had settled in Brooklyn, New York. By the time his brother Ira was born in 1896, his father had adopted the name Gershwine; George was born Jacob Bruskin Gershwine two years later.

As a child, he did not show much interest in music until Ira started